The Marriage Counselor

By Joey Ouellette

NOTE: Throughout this selection, the judge serves as the silent "marriage counselor"

TIGER: *(to audience)* She is impossible, totally, totally impossible. I can't stand living with her for another hour, another minute. I'm losing my hair I'm so upset. It's coming out in big hunks. I'm getting constipated. And it's all her fault.

SUSAN: *(to audience)* I can't take any more of this. He is an insensitive, self-centered jerk. I've tried, believe me, I've tried, my mother says don't give up, don't give up, but of course she's already divorced. I've had enough. I have. It's all his fault.

TIGER and SUSAN: *(Together.)* See what I mean?

INTRODUCTION

The Marriage Counselor by Joey Ouellette

TIGER: She shaves her legs with my razor, my razor, the one I use on my face!

SUSAN: He shaves his face with my razor, my razor, the one I use on my legs!

TIGER and SUSAN: *(Together.)* It's unsanitary.

TIGER: She leaves her dirty underwear all over the house!

SUSAN: He clips his fingernails in the living room!

TIGER: She eats potato chips in bed. And she won't share.

SUSAN: That's because you're getting fat.

TIGER: Me? I'm getting fat?

SUSAN: I'm glad you agree.

TIGER and SUSAN: *(Together.)* **TIGER:** Do you see? Do you see? **SUSAN:** He is totally unreasonable!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SUSAN: Maybe we should try to speak one at a time.

TIGER: Nana na na na na na.

SUSAN: Don't be such a child.

TIGER: Don't be such a . . . virus.

SUSAN: Virus? I'm a virus?

TIGER: Look, do you want to do this, or what? I could just walk out of here! You wanted to come to a marriage counselor, I agreed, as usual I gave in-

SUSAN: *(Interrupts.)* Ho ho ho! You gave in! You never give in! Your stubbornness is the cause of every problem we have.

TIGER: My stubbornness? I'm stubborn?

SUSAN: I'm glad you finally admit it. . . . It's not my fault you're not as smart as I am.

TIGER: Oh, I am, I am. It's just that you're cold and I'm sensitive.

SUSAN: You mean stupid.

TIGER: No, I mean sensitive.

SUSAN: No, you mean sensitive.

TIGER: No, I mean stupid. You're the sensitive one. I'm the stupid one. *(TIGER realizes what he's said. SUSAN smiles at him.)*

SUSAN: Why don't we start at the beginning?

TIGER: We don't have time to start at the beginning. We're paying this bozo, aren't we? *(To the "Judge".)* Sorry.

SUSAN: Two hundred dollars an hour.

TIGER: I take that sorry back.

SUSAN: I'll go first.

TIGER: I'll go first.

SUSAN: We've never-

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

TIGER: *(Continuing.)* Been to a marriage counselor

SUSAN: *(Continuing.)* Before-

TIGER *(Continuing.)* But-

SUSAN: *(Continuing.)* We thought we should try it.

TIGER: We've tried everything else.

SUSAN: We really have. . . . Self-help books.

TIGER: Acupuncture.

SUSAN: Talking to friends.

TIGER: Hypnosis.

SUSAN: Talking to psychics.

TIGER: Prostitutes. *(Silence.)* Did I say prostitutes? I meant to say Protestants. Protestants. Talking to Protestants.

SUSAN: Relatives.

TIGER: Talking to Catholics.

SUSAN: Clergymen.

TIGER: Going to the houses of Jehovah's Witnesses.

SUSAN: Lawyers. *(Silence.)* Did I say lawyers?

TIGER: I, I think you did. Have you been to a lawyer?

SUSAN: Have you been to a prostitute?

TIGER: Don't be silly! What would I go to a prostitute for? I mean I know what I go to a prostitute for, I mean, I haven't been to one, but I've seen pictures. I mean I haven't seen pictures, I just heard about it from a friend of mine, who I haven't seen in seventeen years, and I haven't had any contact with since. It was before I even met you. Have you been to a lawyer?

SUSAN: Yes.

TIGER: *(Screaming.)* Ahhhh!

SUSAN: Maybe we should start at the beginning.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

TIGER: All the way back to the beginning? At four dollars a minute? This is more expensive than phone sex. Not that I've ever done it. I had a friend, I haven't spoken to him in years, he used to do, and no I didn't watch. He just told me about it. Not on the phone. It was seventeen years ago, before I even met you.

SUSAN: So that's what those calls on the phone bill were.

TIGER: What calls?

SUSAN: All those thirty second ones.

TIGER: I have no idea what you're talking about.

SUSAN: *(To the "Judge".)* Are we hopeless? What do you think?

TIGER: I think I want to go home.

SUSAN: After we fought all day, after we fought all the way here in the car, and all through our nice lunch, you want to just walk home and waste all that we've accomplished today?

TIGER: Did you say walk home?

SUSAN: We're finally here, at a marriage counselor's. We've been talking about coming since our honeymoon.

TIGER: You did say walk home, didn't you? Don't deny it now!

SUSAN: I took the car keys out of your pocket in the elevator on the way up.

TIGER: I wondered what that tingling was. Why did you take them?

SUSAN: Just in case this doesn't tum out. I'm giving you this last chance. And then I'm keeping the car.

TIGER: Well, as long as you're being open-minded about it.

SUSAN: Can we get on with this?

TIGER: Hey, I'm not the one holding things up.

SUSAN: Oh, it's all my fault.

TIGER: Okay.

SUSAN: Can we start at the beginning?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

TIGER: Alright. Do you want to go first? See, see, I'm trying, I'm trying to be polite, I'm trying to make this work. I'm trying. I'll go first. Unless you want to go first. But don't start with the barbecue.

SUSAN: I won't. You see, my sister Jeanine is like my best friend, and she said you don't get out enough, you don't date enough, and so she took me to this barbecue

TIGER: *(Interrupting.)* She's starting with the barbecue!

SUSAN: I have to start with the barbecue!

TIGER: You said you wouldn't!

SUSAN: I have to!

TIGER: No you don't! You don't have to do anything. That's what you always tell me. I don't have to listen to you. I don't have to do the dishes. I don't have to dress up like a nurse. Oh, I guess that's getting kind of personal.

SUSAN: But the barbecue is the beginning of us. Where do you want me to start then?

TIGER: Never mind. Just never mind. I'll go first. She's having an affair!

SUSAN: Tiger!

TIGER: What? You don't want me to tell strangers? You want me to lie? What's the point in coming here and paying two hundred dollars an hour if we're going to lie?

SUSAN: *(Interrupts)* I'm not having an affair.

TIGER: Quiet woman! It's my turn, it's my turn and for once in my life I'm going to take my turn and talk when it's my turn to talk! I forgot what I was going to say. Now I remember! I remember. Let me ask you, how many times a week does UPS come to your house? I mean your office? Once maybe? Twice? They come everyday, everyday to my house, when I'm at work and she's, she's home alone in her bathrobe. Five days a week!

SUSAN: I order a lot of books.

TIGER: She's sleeping with every UPS man in the country! They're probably taking turns

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and fighting over who gets to come to my house. People are dying because the medicines they need are sitting in my driveway, getting cold. The whole UPS company is going to fold. Fold. And then no one will be able to communicate and the whole country will fall apart.

SUSAN: Wait a minute-

TIGER: *(Interrupts.)* No! No! No! No! No! No! I don't want to listen to your lies. What's the point in parading them through here? I told the truth. That is the whole true story, and that's why I didn't want to come here. There is no point. We have no future. How can we have one?

SUSAN: May I speak? It's true that I have thought about other men, but I think that's normal.

TIGER: I've never thought about other men.

SUSAN: I've been faithful. It's true that I find a man in uniform irrestible, but I have been faithful. I've just been ordering a lot of books . . . I wouldn't be fantasizing about other men if you loved me!

TIGER: I did love you!

SUSAN: He never wanted me. He wanted my sister.

TIGER: Oh, we're back to the barbecue again! Can't we leave the barbecue behind us?

SUSAN: We went to a barbecue-

TIGER: *(Interrupts.)* She doesn't ever listen, do you see, do you see, never listens to me.

SUSAN: I went to the barbecue with my sister Jeanine.

TIGER: Ah! Ah! Ah! Ahhhhhhh!

SUSAN: Jeanine and I are like best friends, or we were then. Tiger was already at the barbecue. He started talking to us, my sister and I, we were standing side by side. Tiger said will you go out with me? I couldn't believe it. I said yes. But he wasn't talking to me. He was talking to Jeanine. He was asking Jeanine.

TIGER: It's not true, it's not true. Look at me, would you? I'm a normal, ugly, boring,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

stupid, repulsive man. I was asking both of them. I was asking everybody. I asked trees and mailboxes.

SUSAN: He was asking Jeanine. He didn't want to go out with me.

TIGER: Okay, okay, it's true I was more attracted to her sister, but I was a little drunk, and Jeanine kept laughing at everything I said and she wasn't wearing a Tee-shirt that said, "I hate everything".

SUSAN: You said you liked that tee-shirt! . . . So Tiger took me out on a date.

TIGER: I took her someplace nice.

SUSAN: He took me fishing.

TIGER: It was a nice boat.

SUSAN: I fell in the water.

TIGER: Never touched her!

SUSAN: He nudged me a little bit but I thought he was being romantic, not trying to push me out of the boat.

TIGER: Alright, alright, the truth is I was passing a little bit of gas and I was moving around to try to hide it, you know, everybody does it. I guess maybe I could have nudged her a little bit.

SUSAN: I can't swim.

TIGER: I saved her though, I saved her! I could have let her drown. Who would have known?

SUSAN: He scooped me out with his big fish landing net.

TIGER: She bent the frame too. I had to buy a new net. Those nets aren't cheap.

SUSAN: He tried to give mouth to mouth. But I wasn't having trouble breathing.

TIGER: Can't blame a guy for trying.

SUSAN: He chipped my tooth with his tooth. He chipped my front tooth, this one right here. *(SUSAN shows the "judge")*

TIGER: It hurt me too, it hurt me too!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SUSAN: He felt so guilty, he asked me out again.

TIGER: How do you know I felt guilty, you're inventing feelings and putting them into my mouth.

SUSAN: Did you feel guilty?

TIGER: Of course I felt guilty. I pushed her into sewer water, hit her over the head with a landing net and chipped her tooth. The least I could do was to ask her out again.

SUSAN: He took me pheasant hunting.

TIGER: *(Uneasy.)* I'm an outdoorsy kind of guy.

SUSAN: He shot me in the rear end.

TIGER: I said I was sorry! It was a light load. She only got a couple of shotgun pellets.

SUSAN: Forty-two! The doctor counted as he dug each one out. I should've known then.

TIGER: She bent over-

SUSAN: *(Interrupts.)* To tie my shoe-

TIGER: *(Interrupts.)* And something that looked like a pheasant landed on her butt. I mean her rear end.

SUSAN: We never did find the bird.

TIGER: I think it got trampled into the dirt when you were jumping up and down screaming and calling me vile names.

SUSAN: He felt really guilty after that.

TIGER: Of course I felt guilty! I shot her. I'd be a horrible person if I didn't feel guilty for shooting someone!

SUSAN: So he asked me to go away with him to a cabin.

TIGER: Can't we talk about something else?

SUSAN: We were cutting firewood.

TIGER: I don't want to talk about this anymore. Let's talk about the barbecue.

SUSAN: He cut three of my toes off.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

TIGER: It was a bad axe, it wasn't my fault, there was something wrong with the axe!

SUSAN: I can't wear open-toed shoes anymore . . . So he proposed to me.

TIGER: I cut her toes off, what was I supposed to do? Sorry about your toes, see you later?

SUSAN: We got married. You probably think I'm stupid, but I didn't see then that he was motivated by guilt. I thought he really liked me for who I was . . . [but] he really wanted me sister Jeanine.

TIGER: It's not true, it's not true!

SUSAN: After we got married she stopped phoning me. She never comes for visits. No Christmas cards. And she just lives a few blocks away.

TIGER: She hates me. Isn't it obvious that her sister hates me? Can't stand the sight of me! Any person in their right mind avoids me.

SUSAN: My sister loves me and she doesn't want to ruin my marriage. So she's stayed away these past six years. Afraid that just the sight of her would tempt him into . . .

TIGER: Into what?

SUSAN: Adultery.

TIGER: That's ridiculous! That's insane! What's adultery?

SUSAN: You never wanted me. Only Jeanine.

TIGER: No, I'm a jerk and Jeanine knows it. That's why she stays away. Just like your mother.

SUSAN: You punched mother.

TIGER: It was an accident. She hit me first!

SUSAN: She was brushing a bug off your face.

TIGER: How was I supposed to know that?

SUSAN: You don't want me. You want Jeanine.

TIGER: That's crazy. Do you call her? Do you send her a Christmas card? Why should

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

she send you one? It doesn't mean anything.

SUSAN: She's never visited me.

TIGER: That's because she can't get in our driveway because it's filled with UPS trucks.

SUSAN: You've never loved me! You just married me out of guilt!

TIGER: No, I married you because I'm stupid! Stupid stupid stupid stupid!

SUSAN: *(to judge.)* Make him stop, make him stop!

TIGER: *(to judge)* Make her stop! She's the one who had to bring up that stupid barbecue.

SUSAN: I wish I'd never gone to it!

TIGER: Not as much as I do!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joey Ouellette
ISBN: 978-0573626708
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): April 1999

AWARD HISTORY

Ohio State Qualifier